GOP Consultant Network — Form Redesign & Backend Database Design

0. Diagnosis of the current form

Before redesigning, worth naming what's actually wrong, because it shapes every fix below:

Taxonomy mismatch. GOP sells itself around the S.C.A.L.E. matrix (Business Transformation, Revenue & Growth Acceleration, Operations & Financial Discipline, People & Performance, AI-Led Efficiency, PE Readiness & Institutional Infrastructure, Capital & Ecosystem Access). The form's "Delivery function(s)" list doesn't reflect this — there's nothing for costing architecture, QoE/PE readiness, pricing strategy, governance, or capital/ecosystem access. If a client asks "who can get us diligence-ready," today's data can't answer that query, even though it's core to the pitch.
No case study capture despite being explicitly required. The 200–300 character free-text boxes ("key skills," "relevant experience") are too short to hold a real case study and too unstructured to be searchable later. A consultant could write a paragraph of adjectives and it would look identical in the database to someone with three quantified turnarounds.
No unique ID field at all. Since this is invitation-only and needs a tracking system, ID assignment has to be a backend function, not a form field — but the form needs to capture *who invited whom* so the ID and the referral chain can be generated correctly.
Nothing about the commercial/engagement model. GOP engages on a project-cost, skin-in-the-game basis. The form doesn't ask how the consultant prices their own time, what engagement structures they'll accept (fractional/interim/advisory/project), or availability — all of which GOP needs *before* a client conversation, not after.
Industry list too shallow for a manufacturing-focused firm. "Manufacturing" as one checkbox is close to useless when the firm's stated target is ₹150–500cr manufacturers; sub-verticals matter (auto components vs. chemicals vs. FMCG vs. industrial equipment have almost nothing in common operationally).
No conflict-of-interest / exclusivity check, which matters more for an invitation-only operator network than a normal freelancer marketplace.

The redesign below fixes these while deliberately keeping the form short — most of the added rigor lives in *structure* (dropdowns, tagging, bounded fields) rather than in *more essay questions*.

1. Form design principles

Tag, don't narrate. Every taxonomy item (function, industry, skill) should be a selectable tag mapped to a database ID, not free text. Free text is reserved for the one place it earns its keep: case studies.
One rich structured case-study block beats five vague essay questions. Replace the four short-answer questions with a single repeatable "Case Study" section (see §3) — 1 required, up to 3 optional. This is where "success stories" actually get captured in a form GOP can query later ("show me every case study tagged Working Capital + Manufacturing + >₹50cr impact").

Separate "what you know" from "what you'll do." Skills/functions/industries describe capability. A distinct "Engagement Profile" section (§4) describes availability, commercial model, and constraints — this is what actually gets used when GOP is slotting someone into a live deal.
Keep it invitation-aware. Since every consultant enters via invitation, capture the referral chain and let the backend derive the ID — don't make the applicant invent or guess an ID.
Bound every free-text field explicitly (as the current form does) but raise the case-study limits enough to hold a real story (150–200 words per sub-field, not per whole answer).

2. Revised form structure

Section A — Identity & Contact

Full name
Email
Mobile
LinkedIn URL *(new — this is your cheapest verification signal and belongs in an invitation-only network)*
City / State / Country
Open to remote engagements (Y/N)
Willing to travel (None / Domestic / Domestic + International) *(new — relevant given GOP's promoter-led manufacturer client base is often outside metro hubs)*
Invited by — dropdown/search of existing consultant IDs, or "Direct/GOP-sourced" *(new — this is what lets the backend build a referral graph and is a natural side-effect of the invite-only model)*

Section B — Level & Tenure

Keep existing bands, but decouple level from a single number:

Total years of experience (existing bands: 5–10 / 10–18 / 18–25, add "25+")
Years in an **operating role** vs. years in **pure advisory/consulting** roles *(new, two numbers not one — GOP's pitch is "operator-led," so this is the single most on-brand data point missing from the form)*
Largest team size directly managed
Largest P&L / budget owned (band: <₹5cr / ₹5–25cr / ₹25–100cr / ₹100cr+ / Not applicable)

Section C — Delivery Pillars *(realigned to S.C.A.L.E., replaces "Delivery function(s)")*

Select all that apply, each with sub-tags so tagging stays granular without exploding the top-level list:

Business Transformation — Strategy design / Diagnostic-to-execution / Organisation design / Change management
Revenue & Growth Acceleration — New business development / Key account management / Pricing strategy / Cross-sell-upsell playbooks / Lead generation
Operations & Financial Discipline — Costing architecture / MIS design / Working capital management / Supply chain / Financial controls
People & Performance — Talent acquisition / L&D / KPI-KRA design / Performance management systems
AI-Led Efficiency — Process automation / Agentic AI / Applied data science / Decision-support tooling

PE Readiness & Institutional Infrastructure — QoE reporting / Governance design / Board reporting / Due-diligence prep
Capital & Ecosystem Access — PE/VC relationships / Fundraise support / Deal sourcing

(This structure means "Skills" as a separate flat list — Excel, PowerPoint, MIS, BI — collapses into sub-tags under the relevant pillar instead of sitting as an unrelated parallel taxonomy, which is what makes today's form's two lists partially redundant.)

Section D — Industry Depth

Two-level tagging:

Primary sector(s): Manufacturing / Services / Consulting / Private Equity / Banking & Financial Services / Other
If Manufacturing selected, sub-vertical multi-select: Auto & Auto Components / Chemicals & Specialty Chemicals / Textiles & Apparel / FMCG & Consumer / Pharma & Life Sciences / Industrial Equipment & Capital Goods / Packaging / Electronics / Other
Revenue band(s) of companies you've worked with (mirrors GOP's own client bands: <₹150cr / ₹150–300cr / ₹300–500cr / ₹500cr+) *(new — directly matches GOP's target client profile, so it's a high-value, low-cost field)*

Section E — Case Studies *(replaces the four short essay questions — this is the core fix)*

One required, up to three optional. Each is a structured mini-record, not an essay:

Field	Type	Limit
Title	Short text	80 chars
Client industry & size band	Dropdown (reuses Section D taxonomy)	—
Delivery pillar(s) involved	Multi-select (reuses Section C taxonomy)	—
Your role	Lead / Core team / Contributor	—
Situation (what was broken)	Text	200 chars
Intervention (what you did)	Text	250 chars
Outcome (quantified)	Text — *nudge for a number: %, ₹, time saved*	150 chars
Duration	Months (number)	—
Can this be named/referenced, or must it stay anonymized?	Named / Anonymized-only	—

This gives GOP a searchable outcome record ("₹ working capital released," "% margin improvement") instead of adjectives, while keeping each entry genuinely fillable in under two minutes.

Section F — Engagement Profile *(new section — currently entirely absent)*

Preferred engagement type: Fractional/part-time / Full project deployment / Advisory-only / Interim operator role
Availability: days/week you can commit
Notice period
Indicative commercial expectation (day rate or project-fee band — ranges, not exact figures, to keep it low-friction)
Currently engaged elsewhere / any exclusivity or non-compete constraints (Y/N + free text if Y, 150 chars) *(new — important given invitation-only, reputational nature of the network)*

Section G — A Few Questions (trimmed, kept qualitative)

Keep only two of the current four, since case studies now carry the evidentiary weight:

Why do you want to be part of GOP? (200 chars)
How will you typically deliver your engagements — solo, with a small pod, embedded full-time, etc.? (200 chars)

(Drop "What is GOP?" — it screens for reading comprehension, not capability, and adds no data value to the backend.)

Section H — Documents & Consent

Upload CV (existing)
Upload supporting case study deck/deliverable sample (optional)
Consent checkbox: data storage/processing for the purpose of consultant-client matching *(new — needed once you're running a structured database, not just a mailbox of resumes)*

3. Unique ID system

Two design options — recommendation is A:

Option A (recommended): Immutable, meaningless serial ID + rich attribute fields Format: `GOP-C-000001` (a plain incrementing number, zero-padded, prefixed with a fixed org code).

Assigned once at approval, never reused, never changed.
All the "meaning" (level, pillar, industry) lives in queryable fields, not encoded in the ID string.
Why this beats a "smart" ID (e.g. `GOP-MFG-PRIN-0007` encoding industry+level): consultants' tags change over time (they add a pillar, move up a level) — a smart ID either goes stale or has to be reissued, which breaks every reference to it (contracts, past engagement records, invoices). A dumb sequential ID never needs to change.
Human-friendly variant if you want something more memorable for internal use: `GOP-{YY}-{sequence}` e.g. `GOP-26-0143` (year joined + sequence within year) — still immutable, just carries a join-year hint.

Option B (not recommended, but noted since it's tempting): embed level/pillar in the ID. Only sensible if you're willing to treat the ID as disposable/re-issuable — adds complexity for no real gain over just filtering on the attribute fields.

4. Backend database structure

Relational schema (works in Postgres/MySQL or as an Airtable/Notion-style structure if you want something non-engineering-heavy to start).

Core tables

`consultants` (master record)

```
consultant_id      PK, e.g. GOP-C-000001
full_name
email              unique
mobile
linkedin_url
city, state, country
open_to_remote     boolean
travel_willingness enum(none, domestic, domestic_international)
level              enum(consultant, sr_consultant, principal)
total_years_exp    int
operating_years_exp int
advisory_years_exp int
max_team_managed   int
max_pnl_band       enum
invited_by         FK -> consultants.consultant_id (nullable, self-referential)
status             enum(invited, applied, approved, active, inactive, declined)
date_invited
date_applied
date_approved
cv_file_url
consent_flag       boolean
created_at, updated_at
```

`pillars` (lookup — the 7 S.C.A.L.E. categories)

```
pillar_id  PK
name
```

`sub_tags` (lookup — sub-capabilities within a pillar)

```
tag_id    PK
pillar_id  FK -> pillars
name
```

`consultant_capabilities` (junction — many-to-many)

```
consultant_id  FK -> consultants
tag_id       FK -> sub_tags
```

`industries` (lookup, self-referential for sector > sub-vertical)

```
industry_id    PK
name
parent_industry_id  FK -> industries (nullable, null = top-level sector)
```

`consultant_industries` (junction)

```
consultant_id  FK -> consultants
industry_id    FK -> industries
```

`case_studies`

```
case_study_id    PK
consultant_id    FK -> consultants
title
client_industry_id FK -> industries
client_size_band  enum
role          enum(lead, core_team, contributor)
situation_text
intervention_text
outcome_text
duration_months   int
referenceable    enum(named, anonymized_only)
created_at
```

`case_study_pillars` (junction — a case study can span multiple pillars)

```
case_study_id  FK -> case_studies
pillar_id     FK -> pillars
```

`engagement_profile` (1:1 with consultants, kept separate since it changes more often than identity data)

```
consultant_id        FK -> consultants (PK)
engagement_type      enum(fractional, full_project, advisory_only, interim)
availability_days_week  int
notice_period_days   int
rate_band            text or enum
currently_engaged    boolean
exclusivity_notes    text
last_updated
```

`client_engagements` (this is the payoff table — what GOP actually uses day to day)

```
engagement_id   PK
client_name
client_industry_id FK -> industries
pillar_ids      (or junction table client_engagement_pillars)
start_date, end_date
status          enum(prospect, active, completed)
```

`engagement_staffing` (junction — who's staffed on what)

```
engagement_id   FK -> client_engagements
consultant_id   FK -> consultants
role_on_engagement
```

Why this shape

The **pillar → sub-tag → consultant** chain is the query GOP will run constantly: "*client needs Working Capital + Manufacturing (Auto Components) support — who fits?*" becomes a straightforward join across `consultant_capabilities`, `consultant_industries`, and `case_studies`.

Case studies as their own table (not a text blob on the consultant record) means a consultant with 3 case studies spanning different pillars shows up correctly in searches for any of those pillars — a single flat "success story" text field wouldn't let you do that.

`engagement_profile` **separated from** `consultants` because availability/rate/notice-period data goes stale fast and shouldn't require touching the core identity record every time someone updates it.

`client_engagements` **+** `engagement_staffing` close the loop — this is what turns the form from a static resume bank into an actual tracking system, since it lets GOP see engagement history per consultant over time, not just self-reported capability at sign-up.

Self-referential `invited_by` on the consultants table gives you the referral graph for free — useful both for network growth analytics and for informal vetting (who vouched for whom).

5. What this buys you in practice

A client conversation like *"we need someone who's actually run working-capital discipline in a ₹200–300cr auto-components business and can start in three weeks"* becomes one query against tags + case studies + engagement_profile — instead of someone at GOP manually rereading CVs. That's the actual test of whether the form/database design succeeded.